

BEYOND THE KINGDOM — Series Format Bible

Document 01 · Locked Canon · Format & Production Rules

In-universe "today": Monday, January 3, 2005 (Premiere Day)

1. Locked Facts (Canon — Do Not Change)

Item	Locked Value
Title	Beyond the Kingdom
Format	Daytime soap opera (serial drama), Monday–Friday
Series premiere (in-universe)	Monday, January 3, 2005
Present day	2005 — the story moves forward in real time from here
Setting	A fictional, private, gated luxury community in the affluent Atlanta, Georgia area
Core family	The Donohues — Victor, Joan, Jasmine, Natasha, and Alvin
Family identity	A "powerful and prestigious multigenerational family" — "Black Royalty"
Cast	Primarily African American, with a few non-Black characters
Storytelling tools	Screenplay-format scenes + in-world news/media headlines + 2005-era internet & fan reaction
Deliverables	Every document is also delivered as a PDF

Premise: Set in a fictional gated community in the affluent Atlanta area, *Beyond the Kingdom* tells the story of a wealthy Black family in a posh, gated community. At the center of the story is the Donohue Family — Victor, Joan, Jasmine, Natasha, and Alvin — a powerful and prestigious multigenerational family known as "Black Royalty."

Character bios, birthdays, and backstories arrive in the next document (Document 02 — Character Bible).

2. Episodes Per Year — 250

Answer: 250 new episodes per year.

- A real daytime soap airs every weekday — about 260 airdates per year.
- In 2005 there are 255 weekday airdates after the usual holiday preemptions (Memorial Day, Independence Day, Labor Day, Thanksgiving, and the Christmas observance).

- Taking out about 5 more days for real-world preemptions (breaking news, sports, presidential addresses) leaves **250**. That is the real network daytime standard for a one-hour soap.
- Every broadcast week is 5 episodes, and the story moves on each weekday.

3. Season Numbering — The Broadcast-Season Model

Answer: Number seasons by the U.S. broadcast TV season, which runs from mid-September to mid-September. Number episodes cumulatively and never reset them.

Real daytime soaps work this way. They don't restart at "Episode 1" each season. The episode counter runs continuously (for example, *Episode #5,000*), and "seasons" are industry bookkeeping tied to the fall broadcast season. A soap that premieres mid-season (like ours, in January) has a shortened first season.

Season	Broadcast Window	Airdate Slots	New Episodes	Episode Numbers
Season 1 (Premiere Season)	Mon Jan 3, 2005 – Fri Sep 16, 2005	182	180	#0001 – #0180
Season 2	Mon Sep 19, 2005 – Fri Sep 15, 2006	254	250	#0181 – #0430
Season 3 and beyond	Mid-September to mid-September	~255	250	Continues cumulatively

How to reference an episode: *Season 1 · Episode #0001 · Monday, January 3, 2005*

Holidays with no new episode in Season 1: Memorial Day (Mon May 30, 2005), Independence Day (Mon Jul 4, 2005), Labor Day (Mon Sep 5, 2005). Two more Season 1 dates are held for real-world preemptions.

Sweeps periods (ratings months — the biggest cliffhangers, weddings, deaths, and reveals land here):

- February 2005 sweeps: about Feb 3 – Mar 2, 2005
- May 2005 sweeps: about Apr 28 – May 25, 2005
- November 2005 sweeps: about Oct 27 – Nov 23, 2005
- **Season finale:** Friday, September 16, 2005 — the biggest Friday cliffhanger of the year

4. Serialized vs. Standalone — 95% / 5%

Answer: 95% serialized, 5% standalone.

- **95% serialized:** Every episode continues the storylines from the day before. Storylines overlap, pick up where they left off, and pay off weeks or months later. This is the real daytime formula.

- **5% "standalone-feel" specials:** About 12–13 episodes a year. They still count in continuity, but each one centers on a single event or format:
 - Holiday episodes (Thanksgiving, Christmas, New Year's Eve)
 - Flashback / "family history" episodes about the Donohue legacy
 - A wedding, funeral, or gala shown across one full hour
 - "Two-hander" episodes (a single long confrontation between two characters)
 - Anniversary episodes
- **Continuity rule:** Nothing is ever "reset." Every event, injury, secret, marriage, birth, death, and lie is permanent canon unless the story itself changes it (a reveal, a lie exposed, a return).

Continuity Protocol

1. **Master Timeline Log:** Every scene carries a date and time stamp.
2. **Age Tracker:** Ages are calculated from locked birthdays and change on each birthday. A character's age on any date is always exact.
3. **No SORAS without an on-screen reason.** ("Soap Opera Rapid Aging" is a common soap trick. We avoid it to keep it real.)
4. **Story Ledger:** An ongoing list of open secrets (who knows what, and since when).
5. **Relationship Map:** Marriages, divorces, affairs, and paternity, all dated.

5. Genre, Subgenres, Rating & Runtime

Category	Answer
Primary Genre	Daytime Soap Opera / Serial Drama
Subgenres	Family saga · Dynasty/wealth drama · Romantic melodrama · Corporate & political power drama · Mystery/suspense · Legal drama · Crime thriller
Themes	Legacy, power, loyalty, betrayal, secrets, class within the Black elite, faith, ambition, love
Tone	Glamorous, high-stakes, emotional, realistic — "Black Royalty" behind the gates
Rating	TV-14 (D, L, S, V) — suggestive dialogue, strong language, sexual situations, violence (within daytime network standards)
Timeslot	One-hour weekday broadcast (e.g., 1:00–2:00 PM ET)
Runtime	60-minute slot · about 42 minutes of story (2005 network daytime hours ran about 18 minutes of commercials, promos, and credits)

6. Episode Titles

Answer: Real daytime soaps don't give episodes titles. Each episode is identified by its **episode number + air date**, plus an internal **production number**.

Official format:

BEYOND THE KINGDOM — Episode #0001

Air Date: Monday, January 3, 2005

Prod. #BTK-0001

Special exception: Landmark episodes get an in-world promo "event name" for press, ads, and fans. Examples:

- "The Premiere" (Ep #0001)
- "The Donohue Gala" (a sweeps event)
- "The 100th Episode" (Ep #0100)
- "Season Finale" (Ep #0180)

These names appear only in marketing, soap-magazine headlines, and fan chatter. They never replace the number and date.

7. Script Length, Acts & Scenes

Element	Standard
Script length	75–90 pages (target: 80 pages) for a one-hour daytime episode. Daytime scripts are dialogue-heavy and multi-camera, so they run longer than a primetime hour.
Structure	Teaser (Cold Open) + 6 Acts
Scenes	24–30 scenes per episode (target: 28)
Storylines per episode	3–5 storylines rotated through the acts
Scenes per act	Teaser: 1–2 · Acts 1–6: 4–5 each
Act breaks	Every act ends on a "hook" (a reveal, a slap, a stare, a doorbell). Act 6 ends on the day's cliffhanger.
Friday rule	The Friday cliffhanger is the biggest of the week. It keeps the audience coming back Monday.

Episode Template

1. **Title Card:** Episode #, air date, production #, in-universe dates covered
2. **TEASER (Cold Open):** Picks up exactly where the last episode ended
3. **Main Title Sequence**

4. **ACT ONE – ACT SIX:** Scenes rotate between storylines
5. **Cliffhanger Tag**
6. **"Next on Beyond the Kingdom" preview**
7. **Media & Fan Layer:** News headlines, press, and fan posts reacting to that episode's events

Screenplay Scene Format

INT. [LOCATION] - [DAY/NIGHT]
[Day, Month Date, 2005 – Time]

[Action lines in present tense.]

CHARACTER NAME (age)
(parenthetical)
Dialogue.

8. Storytelling Layers (2005 Period Accuracy)

The story is told through three layers:

A. Screenplay Scenes — character-driven dialogue that drives the drama.

B. News & Media (2005 outlets and formats)

- Local Atlanta print and TV news, business pages, society columns, and gossip columns
- National Black media (magazines, cable entertainment news, radio)
- Business press for Donohue corporate storylines
- Soap magazine coverage (weekly soap digests, covers, spoilers)

C. The Internet & Fans — only what existed in 2005

- **Available in 2005:** Soap message boards and forums, AOL, email chains, fan sites, LiveJournal, Xanga, BlackPlanet, MySpace, Blogger/blogs, text messaging (SMS), two-way pagers/Sidekicks/BlackBerrys, flip phones (e.g., Motorola RAZR)
 - **Facebook:** Limited to college students in 2005
 - **YouTube:** Launches in 2005 (public beta in spring). Not usable in January 2005.
 - **Not yet available — never use in 2005 scenes:** Twitter (2006), iPhone (2007), Instagram (2010), smartphone apps, hashtags as a trend culture, streaming services
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9. Timeline & Age Rules

- Every scene carries an **in-universe date and time** (e.g., *Monday, January 3, 2005 — 7:42 PM EST*).
- Atlanta is in **Eastern Time**. EST applies until DST begins on **Sunday, April 3, 2005**, then EDT until **Sunday, October 30, 2005**.
- **Ages are calculated from each character's exact birthday**. A character born June 10, 1950 is **54** on January 3, 2005 and turns **55** on June 10, 2005.
- Birthdays are on-screen events when they matter to the story.
- One airdate usually covers one story day. Timelines can compress (several episodes covering one gala night) or skip (a time jump announced on screen).

10. Quick Reference Summary

Question	Answer
Episodes per year	250 (5 per week, Mon–Fri)
Season numbering	Broadcast season (Sep–Sep); cumulative episode numbers. Season 1 = Jan 3 – Sep 16, 2005 (Eps #0001–#0180)
Serialized / Standalone	95% / 5%
Genre	Daytime Soap Opera / Serial Drama
Subgenres	Family saga, dynasty drama, romance, corporate/political drama, mystery, legal, crime
Rating	TV-14 (D, L, S, V)
Runtime	60-min slot / about 42 minutes of story
Episode titles	Episode # + air date + production # (event names for landmark episodes only)
Script length	75–90 pages (target 80)
Acts	Teaser + 6 Acts
Scenes	24–30 (target 28)

Next: Document 02 — Character Bible (to be provided by the creator).